



HK RAJASHEKAR

HIGH-PROFILE CRICKET MATCHES IN INDIA REQUIRE AN ON-GROUND FORCE OF UP TO 1,000 SECURITY STAFF

cricket and politics is the fact that the IPL Governing Council had disallowed political advertising on TV. With election advertising budgets in crores, few could be happy with the diktat though Modi said he did not believe the policy had an impact on how the Home Ministry and state governments had dealt with the League.

And then there is Sony, the channel formerly known as the IPL rights holder in India. Formerly because the IPL terminated Sony's broadcast rights over the League due to a breach of contractual obligations "on multiple counts". The last live broadcast of the IPL took place on June 2, 2008, so why the contract should be terminated via emails sent at 10.44 p.m. and 3 a.m. on a Saturday night-Sunday morning nine months later is in the realm of wild speculation. Modi however only stretches it as far as sweet euphemism. "Our loyal fans would have to wait a little while longer to hear which channel our broadcast partners will air the DLF Indian Premier League's Season 2 on," he says.

As if tangling with the Government and the courts was not diversion enough, the IPL also faces an increasingly irate section of groups representing overseas players. Even after the

Lahore attack, the IPL will still not share security details with the player groups. At their head is the Federation of Cricketers' Associations (FICA), which represents player bodies of Australia, England, West Indies, Sri Lanka, South Africa and New Zealand. Modi, reiterating the BCCI's persona non grata status to FICA says, "The BCCI/IPL talks directly to the boards of the other countries." This attitude, says FICA President Tim May, was "hurting the reputation" of the IPL. He goes on, "This is not an industrial dispute. It is a matter concerning the players' safety."

After the IPL's third proposed schedule was being moved past the states, and dates and venues were being swapped around at a speed befitting T20 cricket, Modi told waiting reporters in Mumbai that things were "changing by the minute". So when a miffed May says, "Players are now asking, 'what are they hiding?'," the answer could be far from something sinister about security. Try as it might, the IPL cannot quite hide its management trademark: pure seat of the pants. **with Bhavna Vij-Aurora, Stephen David, Amarnath K. Menon, Aditi Pai, Rohit Parihar, Mahalingam Ponnusamy and Elora Sen**

Power Play IPL host states face a tricky 22 yards

STATES	STATUS	POLITICAL PEG
ANDHRA PRADESH	No clash with poll schedule	Hyderabad CA chief is a minister; franchise owners close to government
DELHI	Matches shifted to Mumbai, Nagpur, Ahmedabad, Mohali	Cross-party scramble on to get a handful of 'home' games by urging security agencies to change minds
KARNATAKA	All matches in May after elections	Vijay Mallya has made his contacts in government and bureaucracy work.
MAHARASHTRA	Mumbai may end up hosting 14 out of 59 IPL matches	The Government is not too sure of being able to handle IPL and also the polls but unwilling to admit it
PUNJAB	Will hold five out of seven 'home' matches in April	Punjab Cricket Association chief I.S. Bindra's tangles with administration over land lease issues set aside
RAJASTHAN	All matches shifted to Mumbai and Nagpur	Government's popularity to be hit if all the Rajasthan Royals' matches are to be played in neutral venues
TAMIL NADU	Five matches after the polls, three outside the state	The proximity of BCCI Secretary N. Srinivasan to CM M. Karunanidhi is expected to ensure smooth passage
WEST BENGAL	Will hold seven 'home' matches over 15 days in April	Logistical difficulties aside, in an election year, the Government will not disappoint its sports crazy public